Reader's digest

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Dear Reader

Guardians of India's Soul



ANKIT SAXENA, 23, WAS KILLED because he loved a young woman from a different community. His parents tried to physically stop his assailants, but couldn't save him. Ankit's father Yashpal mustered some strength to speak about the hatred that devoured their only child, when *Reader's Digest* visited their home. His mother Kamlesh just looked vacantly into space. It has been impossible, for me, to get past the agony of a woman who has seen her child bleed to death. Our lives will go on, but what about Kamlesh?

And she isn't alone. There are any number of people whose lives have been shattered by the rage and violence that you can touch in the air today. Armies of brutal hatemongers let loose upon us are going about their mission with chilling precision. India is almost unrecognizable, with spiralling mob violence and gruesome lynchings. Sharply condemning these "horrendous acts of mobocracy", the Supreme Court concluded that they are made worse by the apathy and "inertia of the police" and "the grandstanding by the perpetrators of the crimes on social media". Then there is the shameful valourizing of these criminals by lawmakers.

As we celebrate another Independence Day, we condemn these profound crimes against people who were mostly soft targets with no one to defend them—minorities, migrant workers, tribals and mentally challenged people. Some were urban youth, who simply stopped to ask for directions. This is a grim reminder that the most important freedom—the right to life—is under threat in these times. Remaining mute bystanders is not an option for us any more.

Looking for hope, we turned to India's youth. Our cover story 'What Freedom Means to Young India' captures powerful voices, both searing and uplifting. 'How Free Are We?' by Paranjoy Guha Thakurta (p 42) helps us make sense of freedom in a digital world. Andrew Otis's column (p 62) is a fascinating account of the freedom of the press in 18th-century Bengal. Of course, there's a selection of the best reading from around the world.

Heroes don't always come dressed like movie characters. Gagandeep Singh was in his uniform when he came between a man and a mob (p 86). Ankit's parents, who chose love and compassion, in the face of unimaginable loss (p 80), look ordinary. They are the real guardians of India's soul. Salute!

Sanghamitra

Send an email to **editor.india@rd.com**

PHOTOGRAPH BY ANAND GOGOI, HAIR & MAKE-UP BY ROLIKA PRAKASH

Over to You

FEEDBACK ON OUR JUNE ISSUE

WRITE & WIN!

THROUGH THE LENS



Your cover story, 'A World Of Wonder', was truly wonderful! Each picture recounts a different tale. My thanks to the photographers for their painstaking work. I feel Gemma Ferrando needs a special mention for the lovely photograph of her daughter yawning!

SURINDER PAL, *New Delhi*

A MESSAGE OF PEACE

'If I Ruled The World' that featured Ustad Amjad Ali Khan was thought-provoking. What is happening around the world today is truly sad: man against man, the proliferation of nuclear power and the destruction of human beings. Why? Where is all the compassion, love and humanity?

S. N. SAROJA, *Pune*

IT'S HEADS-UP NOW

'Dial Down Your Migraine' was well-researched. As I have been suffering from migraine for over a decade, I can vouch for it. Last year, I consulted an Ayurvedic doctor in Bengaluru associated with Arya Vaidya Sala, Kottakal, and have been on their medication for nearly nine months. The frequency of the bouts has dropped. I know what a relief it has been and migraine patients will certainly know what I mean. When a migraine comes on, I take a painkiller and sleep in a cool, dark room.

S. LAKSHMAN, *Bengaluru*

STEP OUT OF THE SHADOWS

Swarna Rajagopalan must be congratulated for highlighting how women perceive themselves as inadequate in 'Heroine Of Her Own Epic'. Women must value themselves and their work.

Literacy and education bring economic freedom and freedom of expression. Women's empowerment is closely linked to their access to education. However, the decision to plan a family remains with men. The girl child is still not welcome. Housekeeping is considered a lesser job as it is not linked to monetary benefits. As women we must realize our own worth, learn to respect ourselves, discarding age-old prejudices and be equal participants in nation-building. **DR SUJATA SETTY,** *Noida*

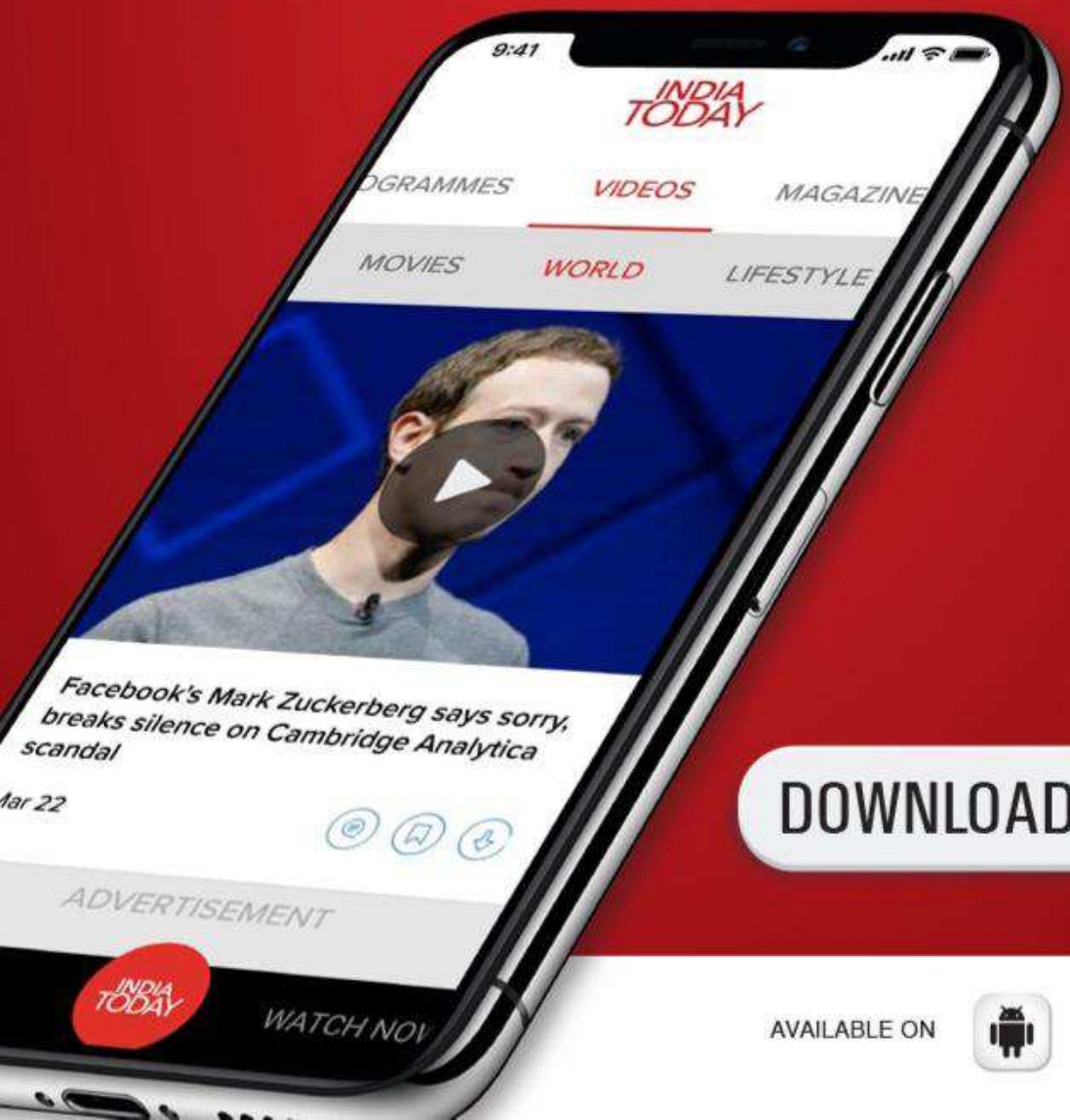
Dr Sujata Setty gets this month's 'Write & Win' prize of ₹1,000.—**EDs**

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IT'S THE HEART

Wilma Derksen's 'I Want To Forgive' emphasizes how human beings have the will to decide. When you forgive, you enter a circle of gratitude, joy and bliss. According to Thich Nhat Hanh, the Vietnamese Buddhist monk and peace activist, letting go is not an art, it is just being heartful!

DR N. GOPALAKRISHNAN, ***Bengaluru***

A QUESTION OF CHOICE

A basic ethical principle in medicine is of patient autonomy. It indicates that a person of sound mind (compos mentis) has the right to refuse treatment even if there is a definite risk of incurring serious complications (including death).

One should have the freedom to refuse resuscitation and be allowed a quick and painless death when the alternative is extended periods in a persistent vegetative state. If there's no option of a life with dignity, then the next best thing would be death with dignity. **DR BHUVANESWARI J. NAIR,** ***Thiruvananthapuram***

A MOTHER REMEMBERS

'Memories Of June' took me back two decades, to my own summer holidays when I spent my days joyfully meeting my relatives from all over. Today, I am a single mother and my son Arjun is five. His summer holidays mean a 10-day vacation and then back to daycare as I have to go to work. I feel guilty, as though I am responsible for stealing away his childhood in pursuit of my life and career. Usually I bury it, but your editorial brought it forth. It's good to be in touch with oneself for a change. **OJASWINI,** ***Pune***

TINY TEACHERS

The only way to ensure human existence is by learning and adaptability. 'When Tara Showed Me The Way' depicts this beautifully. With a focused mind and untiring perseverance, anything can be achieved. Being taught by one's child, though, is the most endearing tutorial!

DR YOGARAJ CHANNE GOWDA, ***Bengaluru***

PRACTISE CAUTION

While the tips given in '7 Ways To Make More Time' could be useful, I don't agree when it comes to 'learn while you drive'. Listening to an audiobook while driving can affect the driver's cognitive functions, causing a serious distraction, which can prove to be dangerous, even fatal. Driving manuals warn against any such habit, including that of listening to music while driving. **BRIG. C. P. TIWARI,** ***Dehradun***

A CORRECTION

The June issue erroneously referred to the Nobel Prize as the Norwegian Prize. It should have read 'the Swedish Prize'. The error is regretted. **—EDs**

Write in at editor.india@rd.com. The best letters discuss RD articles, offer criticism, share ideas. Do include your phone number and postal address.

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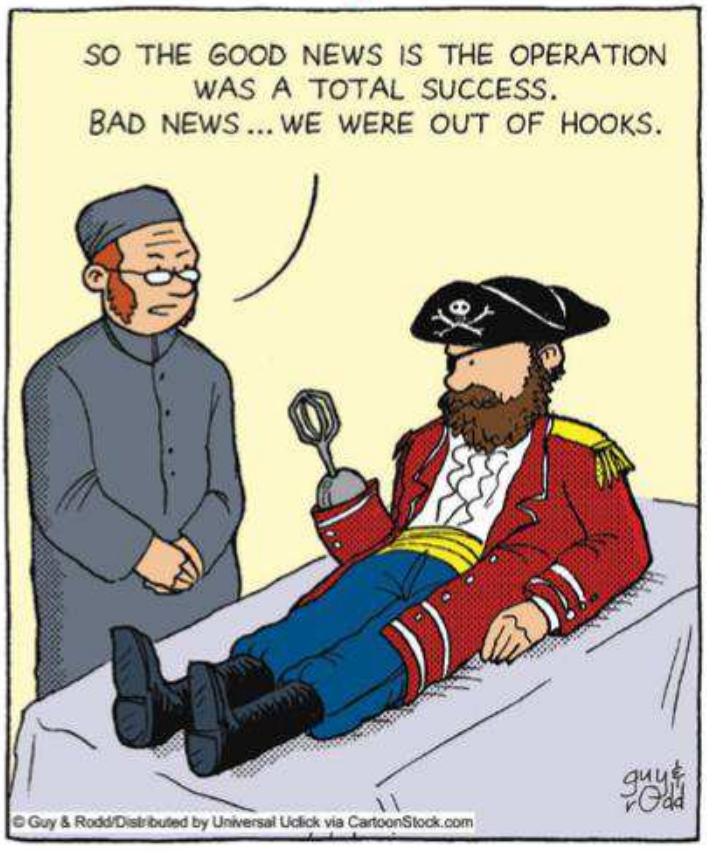
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Humour in Uniform



GUY & RODD/CARTOONSTOCK

MY WIFE AND I were watching a documentary about US Navy SEALs going through POW (prisoner of war) training. Part of the exercise called for them to be placed in dog cages to simulate being captured.

"You know," I said to her, "when I was in the service, I went through similar training."

I expected her to be awed and impressed. Instead, she asked, "Do you think you can still fit in the cage?"

JOHN UMHEY

WHILE STATIONED at Fort Hood in Texas, I encountered a major on the pavement. As I saluted him, I noticed that his name tag was upside down. Being the good supply sergeant that I was, I brought it to his attention.

He stopped, tilted the name tag up and read it. "Looks OK to me," he said and walked on.

CHARLES R. KING

Reader's Digest will pay for your funny anecdote or photo in any of our jokes sections. Post it to the editorial address, or email: editor.india@rd.com